

HR Department Requirements

Leave Management System — HR Input Document

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This document captures the HR department's requirements for the leave management system. It supplements the product brief and PRD draft circulated by Sarah Chen. Where this document contradicts or adds to those documents, this document should be treated as authoritative for HR-specific requirements — the HR team are the primary users and process owners.

1. Authentication and access

All Meridian Group employees already have accounts in our Azure Active Directory tenant. The leave management system must use Azure AD SSO for authentication. Employees must not be required to create or manage a separate username and password for this system.

This is not optional. Provisioning and deprovisioning employees through a separate system is not something the HR team can maintain. When an employee leaves the company their Azure AD account is deactivated within one hour — that must be sufficient to revoke access to the leave system. We cannot manage a second offboarding step.

- SSO via Azure AD is mandatory for all user roles (employees, managers, HR administrators)
- No local username/password accounts
- Deactivating an Azure AD account must immediately prevent system access
- MFA is enforced at the Azure AD level — the system should not implement its own MFA

Note to engineering: our Azure AD tenant ID is available from IT. Contact Rafal Brzozowski.

2. Manager delegation (approval coverage)

The single most critical gap in our current process is what happens when a manager goes on leave. We have had multiple incidents where employees could not get leave approved because their manager was unreachable. This is unacceptable and must be solved properly.

2.1 How delegation must work

- A manager can designate one delegate at a time
- The delegate must be another manager within Meridian Group — not any employee
- Delegation has a start date and end date — it cannot be open-ended
- When delegation is active, all pending and new approval requests from the manager's direct reports are routed to the delegate
 - The delegate receives the same notifications the original manager would have received
 - The original manager can still see all requests and approvals during the delegation period (read-only access to their team's requests)
- When delegation ends, new requests revert to the original manager automatically
- Requests approved or rejected by the delegate during the delegation period are treated as final — the original manager cannot reverse them after returning

2.2 Acceptance criteria for delegation

%j A manager can set up a delegation in under 2 minutes

- %i The system prevents selecting a non-manager as a delegate
- %i Delegation cannot be set with an end date in the past
- %i An active delegation is visible on the manager's dashboard with start/end dates
- %i When delegation starts, all currently pending requests in the manager's queue are immediately visible to the delegate
- %i The delegate cannot further delegate (no chaining)
- %i Delegation end triggers an email summary to the original manager listing all approvals and rejections made during their absence
- %i HR administrators can create, modify, or end any delegation at any time

2.3 Edge cases to resolve

- What if the designated delegate is also on leave when the delegation period starts? — Proposed: system warns the manager at setup time; HR admin can override
- What if a manager goes on unplanned emergency leave with no delegation set up? — Proposed: HR admin can create a delegation retroactively for open requests
- Delegation across offices (e.g. Warsaw manager delegates to Berlin manager) — permitted

3. Leave types and entitlements

The system must support the following leave types. Entitlement rules vary by contract type and office location — these are synced from BambooHR and must not be hardcoded.

- Annual leave — standard entitlement from BambooHR, accrual-based
- Sick leave — uncapped, but requests over 3 consecutive days require a doctor's note (flagged in system, document upload required)
- Parental leave — maternity, paternity, and shared parental; entitlements vary by jurisdiction (Poland, UK, Germany have different statutory minimums)
- Compassionate leave — up to 5 days, HR-approved only, not manager-approved
- Study leave — requires HR pre-approval, up to 10 days per year
- Unpaid leave — requires both manager and HR approval

Important: parental leave entitlements in Poland, the UK, and Germany are legally different. The system must not apply a single rule. BambooHR holds the correct entitlement per employee — the system should read and display from there, not compute it.

4. Notifications

The following notification events must be supported. Minimum channel is email. In-app notifications are also required for all events below — employees and managers must be able to see a notification centre within the system itself, not only in email.

- Employee submits request !' line manager (or active delegate) notified
- Manager approves or rejects !' employee notified with reason if rejected
- Request pending for more than 48 hours without manager action !' reminder to manager
- Leave starts tomorrow !' reminder to employee and their manager
- Delegation period ends !' summary email to returning manager (see section 2.2)
- Leave balance falls below 5 days !' warning to employee (annual leave only)

The 48-hour reminder for pending requests is non-negotiable. We currently have requests sitting unanswered for weeks because managers forget. This automated nudge is the highest-value notification in the system.

Slack integration: several managers have asked for Slack notifications. This is desirable but not a V1 requirement. Do not delay launch for Slack.

5. HR administrator dashboard

HR administrators need a view of the full organisation, not just their own team. The following capabilities are required.

5.1 Required views

- Organisation-wide calendar: all approved leave across all teams and offices, filterable by office (Warsaw, London, Berlin), department, and leave type
- Pending requests queue: all requests awaiting approval, sortable by submission date
- Balance report: current leave balances per employee, exportable to CSV
- Audit log: every approval, rejection, balance adjustment, and delegation, with timestamp and acting user — not deletable or editable

5.2 Manual overrides

- HR can approve or reject any request regardless of manager decision
- HR can manually adjust leave balances with a mandatory reason field
- HR can cancel approved leave (with notification to employee and manager)
- Balance adjustments appear in the audit log

5.3 Reporting

- Monthly leave summary per department (total days taken by leave type)
- Export format: CSV, compatible with current payroll import template (Priya to provide template to engineering team)

6. Data and compliance

This system processes employee personal data including health-related information (sick leave records may indicate medical conditions). The following requirements are non-negotiable from a legal and compliance perspective.

- All data must be stored and processed within the European Union — no exceptions
- Sick leave records must be accessible only to the requesting employee, their direct manager, and HR administrators — not to colleagues or other managers
- Employees have the right to request an export of all their personal data held in the system
- Employees have the right to request deletion of historical leave records older than 2 years (subject to legal hold exceptions)
- The system must maintain an audit log of all data access to sick leave records
- A Data Processing Agreement must be in place with any third-party services used

Legal reference: GDPR Articles 5, 9 (special category data — health), 15 (right of access), 17 (right to erasure). Our DPO is Eva Lindqvist — contact her before any third-party data processor is selected.

7. Open items from HR

- Who approves an HR administrator's own leave requests? — proposed: another HR admin, or escalate to HR Director; needs confirmation
- Notice period enforcement: should the system reject requests submitted less than X days before the requested start date? If yes, what is X per leave type? — HR to provide rules per leave type
- What is the carry-over policy for unused annual leave at year end? — varies by office; Priya to document per jurisdiction before development starts
- Public holidays: each office has different public holidays — how should these be handled in the

calendar? BambooHR may already have this data